

Edward de Bono

Lateral Thinking & the Six Thinking Hats

1933–2021 · Maltese physician, psychologist & author · Malta · Oxford · Cambridge



"Creativity involves breaking out of established patterns in order to look at things in a different way."

"A conclusion is the place where you got tired of thinking."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

De Bono argued that our default 'vertical' logic digs the same hole deeper. He gave managers deliberate tools to think sideways and to run meetings where a group examines a decision from every angle without fighting — the Six Thinking Hats you will use in Unit 2.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Maltese physician, psychologist and prolific author who studied at Malta, Oxford, Cambridge and Harvard. He coined 'lateral thinking' and built a large body of deliberate thinking tools taught in schools and corporations worldwide.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Lateral Thinking	Solving problems by indirect, non-obvious approaches
Six Thinking Hats	Parallel thinking: facts, feelings, caution, optimism, ideas, process
PO / provocation	Deliberate provocative statements to break patterns
PMI (Plus-Minus-Interesting)	Structured scan of an idea's up- and downsides
Value-driven design of thinking	Thinking as a skill that can be taught directly

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Run meetings in one 'hat' at a time to avoid adversarial debate
- Use provocation (PO) to escape entrenched assumptions
- Apply PMI before judging a new idea
- Separate emotion (Red) from analysis (White/Black/Yellow)
- Assign the Blue hat to manage process and sequence

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Empirical evidence for the tools is mixed and mostly anecdotal
- Can feel gimmicky or over-prescriptive to some teams
- Heavy branding and commercialisation of the methods
- Overlaps with, but is less validated than, cognitive research
- Effectiveness depends heavily on skilled facilitation

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- 'Lateral thinking' entered the Oxford English Dictionary
- Six Thinking Hats adopted by governments and Fortune 500 firms
- Author of more than 60 books, translated widely
- Made 'thinking as a skill' a mainstream corporate idea
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Units 2 and 7 thinking methods

SELECTED WORKS

SIX THINKING HATS <i>Little, Brown</i> DE BONO · 1985	LATERAL THINKING <i>A Textbook of Creativity</i> DE BONO · 1970	SERIOUS CREATIVITY <i>HarperBusiness</i> DE BONO · 1992	THE MECHANISM OF MIND <i>Penguin</i> DE BONO · 1969
---	---	---	---

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

- de Bono, E. (1985) *Six Thinking Hats*. Boston: Little, Brown.
- de Bono, E. (1970) *Lateral Thinking: A Textbook of Creativity*. London: Ward Lock Educational.